

N i c o l e C h e w - H e l b i g

the **shame** paradox

Why we fear most
the emotion that keeps us human

No. 65 Press

THE SHAME PARADOX

Why we fear most
the emotion that keeps us human

Nicole Chew-Helbig

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The clinical material in this book is drawn from many years of practice. All clients are composites. Names, identifying details, and circumstances have been changed and combined so that no individual can be identified, and any resemblance to a particular person is coincidental. Where a person appears under their own name, it is with their consent.

This book is intended for general information and reflection. It is not a substitute for psychotherapy, counselling, or medical care, and nothing in it creates a therapeutic relationship between the author and the reader.

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To Oliver

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My grandparents on their wedding day, Singapore, 1930s.

Peranakan Chinese of Hokkien heritage, they are pictured in traditional wedding dress on the steps of a Peranakan house in Singapore. My father was born in 1940. A few years after this photograph was taken, during the Japanese occupation, my grandfather disappeared. No story of what happened to him came down to me.

Preface

Our “ChatGPT” Moment

This book begins in my consulting room.

Mark looked sheepish as he arrived at the session.

“Doc, I’ve been talking to ChatGPT about my problems.”

Mark had built an engineering firm from nothing. He was several years into treatment for a compulsion he couldn’t speak about to anyone. Our work together was a road filled with potholes. The progress was slow and painful for both of us. He felt the despair of failing himself and even me. I felt the despair of the helpless clinician.

In his quest for *the* solution, he’d taught an AI to respond like me. He fed it all the Gestalt therapy and Psychoanalytic literature he could find, and gave it descriptions of how I worked. Then he’d ask me the same questions he’d asked the machine the night before.

“Hey, your answers are quite close,” he said, with a grin.

Actually, I thought the AI offered smarter answers than I did.

“Oh my. That’s brilliant,” I replied.

We laughed.

Mark was not alone in this. Since these machines arrived, more of my clients come to a session having already asked their question elsewhere, and wanting to know whether I will answer as the machine did.

These exchanges enchanted me, even though I felt a quiet displeasure at being outsmarted by the algorithm. I also felt the comfort of being “off the hook,” as if there were a third companion in the room, doing the kind of mental work I had never been sure was mine to do.

Mark’s openness about my replaceability as a source of answers meant I didn’t have to take it on myself to know everything.

A therapist shouldn’t have to know everything. That’s the point.

Mark could reveal to the AI his compulsions without hesitation. With me, however, something was at stake. He came to therapy

knowing I could fail him. He'd voice his anxiety about the risk of being judged or hurt by me before our sessions, even after years of meeting. Sometimes he'd tell me what he was struggling with in that moment. Often, his frustrations stemmed from slow progress or relapses.

In my self-doubting moments, I told myself that I was failing Mark. I didn't have all the answers. I didn't always say the right things.

We never said so aloud, but this was the essence of therapeutic work: the mutual risk of being seen, the possibility that both of us could get things wrong and still stay in the room.

That's what the AI doesn't offer. In Mark's relationship with ChatGPT, there was no capacity for them to wound each other. There was no possibility for shame to arise. There was also no way for the machine to feel the moral weight of Mark's suffering.

Mark was technically skilled and in therapy long enough to know the benefits and limitations of "therapeutic" AI. He supplemented our work with it and was willing to bring his AI experiments into the room. At first, he wasn't sure how I would react to it. He didn't know, of course, that I, too, am fascinated by the latest advancement in tech. He risked my reaction, but he trusted our relationship enough.

That honesty became the question this book opens and closes on: What makes humans irreplaceable to each other, even in an age of artificial intelligence? To answer it, I had to turn away from the machine and towards the thing it cannot do. This book is about shame.

My Writing Group Discussion

In the months after that session with Mark, clients began reporting how they were using AI to bounce their thoughts off. I took notes about this new resource. I wrote fragments of articles about it and published a paper about it in a psychotherapy journal. I also mentioned to colleagues that I was working on a book about shame

but changed the subject when they asked for more details. This is the book I was too ashamed to write.

The irony was not lost on me. But knowing the irony didn't dissolve the insecurity I felt about writing. After all, I am trained neither as a theologian nor a philosopher. I questioned my right to reinterpret scripture or question psychological frameworks already written elsewhere. The conviction that I would be exposed as presumptuous, unqualified and ridiculous threw a wet blanket on my motivation whenever I opened the manuscript.

In January of 2026, I attended a writing retreat at a colleague's home. It was a real Victorian villa with high ceilings and original corning, a house known to have heard generations of conversations, and many healing ones. Six therapists gathered, each of us carrying manuscripts we were afraid to finish.

Over dinner the first night, enjoying beetroot hummus, our host's sourdough, and good cheese, we turned our conversation to the book of Genesis. Someone had been rereading it and couldn't get past the misogynistic nuances woven into the story's fabric.

We started to count. Someone laughed at how Eve was fashioned from Adam's rib. It was written in this way: she was derivative, like an afterthought made from a spare part. Someone noted that Eve's punishment was pain in childbirth and submission to her husband, as though consciousness itself must cost women more. Someone else caught that Adam's defence was essentially the woman made me do it, the oldest deflection in history, and the story has been read that way ever since. The absurdity is so deeply embedded in our culture that we no longer see it.

"If I were Eve, I wouldn't have needed convincing to eat the fruit," I said. "I want the knowledge of good and evil."

"Me too," someone said. And then someone else. And then we were all nodding, wine glasses in hand, six friends unanimously siding with the woman the story was written to blame. We raised our glasses.

One of us even mounted a defence of God, as if He needed a defence attorney. "He wasn't punishing them. He was protecting

them. From life itself.” We contemplated her words. We went quiet. They sounded true.

That jump-started something from within me. No one needed to say anything profound. What mattered was that I had uttered aloud what was in my mind for years, and I wasn’t dismissed. I was recognised. There was laughter in the room. Yes, me too. The ideas I had been carrying in private, feeling that it was not my place to say, to articulate even to myself, turned out to be, at worst, entertaining dinner conversation.

And I had other things to say about this topic that seemed more treacherous than a feminist reading of Eve. I had a conviction about Tronick’s Still Face experiment. To me, this historical piece of evidence captures not proto-shame or negative affect as described, but shame itself appearing in an infant too young to think in words, months before the developmental psychologists say it should be possible.

I suspect that what we call OCD is compulsive obedience to introjected shame: the need to check as genuflection, the need to confess as submission. I felt with growing certainty that what Brené Brown calls shame is not shame as an affect but what happens after shame has been converted. And that building resilience against shame means, at a structural level, building resilience against the signal of human connection. I had also clinically observed and come to believe that shamelessness is the true pathology. A person who cannot feel shame, I came to think, cannot love.

Some of these ideas I have written into this book. Others press at its edges, waiting for whatever comes next.

The next morning, three people approached me separately. Each said some version of the same thing: “I couldn’t sleep last night. I kept thinking about what you said about Eve. About shame. That hit me somehow.” One of them encouraged me to finish the manuscript.

The next few hours found me feeling unsettled. I experienced what this book is about. Being seen felt awkward. It also felt like a small annihilation.

Eve chose knowledge, withstanding risk. She was willing to let curiosity overrule the fear of being cast out. The avid mountaineer cannot leave the next ascent alone, and I could not leave this book unwritten. Safety in ignorance was not an option. I finally understood I was writing about something I knew from the inside.

An Invitation

I do not promise or advocate shame-free living here. We have company in this territory: the tension between who we really are and who we fear we'll be seen as.

Most of us know shame's weight. If we look closely, we have felt it in our gut at that moment when we want to disappear, when exposure feels like death, when we're convinced that being seen will lead to some form of psychic obliteration.

This fear is as accurate as it is unhelpful. Being seen can put us in vulnerable situations, and vulnerability in the wrong environment is risky. Shame that comes can hurt terribly.

When we stop fleeing shame's impact, when we risk being seen despite the fear of judgement, we experience a way of being in this world: resilience in its raw form. We do more than survive shame. We are changed by it.

On Clinical Material

The three main characters whose stories thread through this book (Mark, Tina, and Clarke) are composites. Their stories are drawn from clinical experience and research material, and do not represent anyone. Details are combined and altered so that no character corresponds to any actual person I have met. These are real patterns, not real people.

Other clinical moments that appear briefly across the chapters are similarly constructed from recurring experiences. The same applies to the named people who appear alongside them (family members, partners, colleagues, friends): their names and

identifying details are invented or altered. Where clients' words appear in quotation marks, these represent the essence of what was communicated, not verbatim transcripts.

I have included moments where clients express culturally inappropriate, internalised racist, or misogynistic views simply because this is what happens in therapy. These expressions often represent what Gestalt therapy calls introjects: beliefs swallowed whole from family and society that clients are in the process of examining. The therapeutic work involves learning to differentiate between inherited beliefs and one's own authentic values. I trust readers to recognise these moments for what they are.

A final note before the book begins. The material ahead includes accounts of compulsion, addiction, childhood neglect, persecution and displacement, sexual predation, and the interior experience of shame at its most painful. If any of what follows resonates with a live wound, I hope you will read gently and put the book down when you need to. If you are in crisis, please reach out to a qualified mental health professional or a local crisis line.

On Cultural Context

This book emerges from years of clinical practice in Asia and Europe. My therapeutic training is rooted in Western modalities; my clinical experience extends beyond them. When cultural details appear (when Tina arrives carrying diagnostic labels that don't hold her story, when Mark navigates the pressures around success and masculinity he was raised into), these details are therapeutically significant, not anthropologically representative. They tell us something about these characters, not about everyone from their cultural backgrounds.

I write from a particular place: Singaporean, raised Catholic, trained in Gestalt psychotherapy in the West, practising with clients whose languages and histories I do not always share. The view from my chair is partial. I have tried to name that partiality when I have noticed it, and to trust the reader to notice it when I have not.

My experience practising across cultures has taught me that individuals are always more complex than any category can hold. The themes this book explores (the longing for connection, the terror of exposure, the weight of inherited shame, the capacity to be changed by encounter) transcend cultural boundaries while being dressed in culturally specific clothing. I have tried to honour both the specificity and the universality.

The clients whose stories appear here come primarily from middle-class professional backgrounds: people with the resources to access long-term psychotherapy. This reflects the scope of the book, not the scope of shame. Shame operates with particular force in conditions of poverty, displacement, racial marginalisation, and systemic inequality: contexts where the relational repair this book describes may be structurally unavailable. Chapter 5 addresses shame as a political weapon and systemic control, but a full treatment of shame in conditions of material hardship deserves its own dedicated work.

I encourage readers to remain curious about their own cultural assumptions as they engage with these stories, including the assumption, perhaps, that shame itself is universally experienced in the way this book describes. It is not. But the capacity for it, I believe, is.

That capacity—to feel shame, and so to be reachable by one another—is what we share. It is where this book begins.

Introduction

I have spent years engaged with the research on shame. Most of it agrees on one thing: shame is an adaptation. It is a social regulator (Goffman, 1956; Keltner & Buswell, 1997), a moral compass (Tangney et al., 2007), an evolutionary necessity (Keltner & Anderson, 2000). Mark Leary called self-esteem our internal gauge of belonging, the sociometer that tells us where we stand with others (Leary et al., 1995); shame is what that gauge feels like when the reading drops. The neuroscience agrees that emotion guides reason rather than distorting it (Damasio, 1994); and when shame regulation fails, so does moral judgement (Beer et al., 2003). The field has freed shame from the language of pathology and placed it where it belongs: in the space between people.

Yet something remains incomplete.

The Clinical Encounter

We see shame appear in the consulting room when it collapses a person mid-sentence, when it makes eye contact impossible and threatens to dissolve the therapeutic alliance itself.

A woman sat across from me, her shoulders hunched, hiding her face behind her hands. She had been trying to tell me about a moment of exposure, something said at work, a mistake made in public, a vulnerability revealed. The words would not come. Her breathing shallowed. Her skin flushed red. As she told me this, she apologised for breaking down, for taking up my time, for having feelings.

The theories suggest that shame should have motivated her to build the social bond, learn from the mistake, and reintegrate into social life. But in that moment, she looked like she was drowning.

What the literature describes as an adaptive signal has become, for her, a frozen state of feeling inherently flawed, unacceptable, and unworthy.

Anyone who has felt this from the inside knows it—the flush, the wish to take up less room, the apology for simply being. That feeling is the premise of this book.

Beyond the Consulting Room

A child stood alone in a school corridor, with no words. He had been sent out for being noisy. His face burned. The humiliation he felt would influence the next twenty years of his life. He begged his mother to bring him to a psychiatrist. An ADHD diagnosis brought respite to the people around him: *now the “problem” had a diagnostic label.*

The man who designs his entire career around avoiding a repeat of his childhood exposure, opting for isolation rather than risking being seen, or the woman who cannot leave her house for weeks after a public mistake because her nervous system perceives social space as a threat, will recount similar childhood experiences. And these are the “mild cases”, stories of relatively successful adults.

Entire families organise themselves around unspoken shame that passes from one generation to the next—the grandfather’s poverty shame lives in the grandson’s body, transmitted through silence and flinching. This is no adaptive signal.

The Paradoxes

If shame protects social bonds, why does it so often destroy them, isolating people in the moments they most need connection? Those who carry the most shame end up the least capable of reaching out to others. They become the most guarded against close relationships, shutting out the connection that could heal them.

If shame corrects behaviour, why do those with the deepest shame often become the most rigid, the least capable of change, and the most locked into patterns that cause the rejection they fear?

If shame is a brief signal meant to guide us back to belonging, why does it become, for so many, an unshakeable sense that the self is fundamentally defective and that being seen will inevitably lead to abandonment?

And perhaps most troubling is this: If shame evolved to preserve our humanity, why do we use it so readily to destroy the humanity of others? The systemic shaming done by institutions, communities, and even families does not gather us back together. It exiles and crushes where it was meant to correct.

What the Literature Leaves Unaddressed

What the scholarship generalises, I keep meeting in particular: shame as it appears between people, and the suffering it entails.

The blind spot in the research methods has left us with a picture in which shame exists only in older children, and not in infants. Since infants cannot use language adequately, or at all, scientists cannot test them for self-conscious evaluations. We have been led to understand that shame happens only later. However, when we look at Edward Tronick's Still Face experiment (Tronick et al., 1978) carefully, we can see shame in infants who cannot yet evaluate themselves or understand rules. The baby whose mother's face goes blank experiences the flush, the gaze aversion, and the bodily collapse of shame before language, before self-concept, before the possibility of cognitive reframing (Schore, 2003).

Chronic shame operates differently from the brief embarrassment examined in the literature. Here, shame makes human connection painful. What was meant to be momentary becomes a permanent state of the nervous system—where exposure equals annihilation, and visibility feels like death (van der Kolk, 2014; Levine, 2010).

Most shame research examines the phenomenon from outside using fMRI studies, behavioural coding, and third-person observation. But shame is the experience of needing to be hidden. What shows itself to an observer is the concealment, never the thing

concealed. The literature misses shame because its methods can only watch. “I feel disgusting,” a client said. “Unclean.” These are free associations, not considered self-evaluations—sensations that live reflexively in the body before they become thoughts. Cognitive evaluations cannot capture them. This book aims to bring the phenomenon of shame itself into view.

For those of us carrying developmental trauma, which is hardship or wounding experienced in infancy, our shame experience is preverbal and somatically encoded; knowing about shame does not prevent the collapse.

We build “shame resilience”, and we still suffer.

Suffering is encoded in us before we learn the words to describe how we feel. Whatever affirmations we make in efforts to overcome feelings of shame float above the wound.

The deeper problem with the current resilience framework is that shame is the felt signal of being in relationship with another, and the neural alarm that fires when the relationship is at risk. The act of “building resilience” against shame may imply putting barriers on relationships: *If I stay at a distance from others, I won’t be hurt*. But the source of our suffering would still be there.

When institutions attempt to create shame-free environments—when schools eliminate all negative feedback in the name of compassion, when workplaces replace accountability with affirmations, when therapeutic communities treat shame as a contaminant to be purged—the opposite often happens. Within environments where shame cannot be named, felt, or processed, shame persists. If feeling shame is the inevitable consequence of being in a relationship, when it arises in spaces that have declared themselves shame-free, the individuals experiencing it are caught in a double bind: “This is a safe space, so that you don’t feel what you are feeling.”

The problem is our inability to accept shame as part of being in relationship. By seeking to avoid the feeling, we lose the power to hold it long enough to metabolise it. The approaches that seek to eliminate or overcome shame as a way of ending the suffering are a

misfire. This book proposes a different orientation: we transcend shame through intimacy with it rather than resilience against it.

This is the territory where language matters and where I believe English falls short.

The distinction between shame and guilt—"I am bad" versus "I did something bad"—was first articulated by Helen Block Lewis (1971) and empirically developed by Tangney and her colleagues over three decades of research (Tangney et al., 2007). Brené Brown (2006, 2012) brought it into popular culture, giving millions of people a framework for something they felt but could not name. John Bradshaw (1988), a generation earlier, named "toxic shame"—shame frozen into identity that no longer signals a momentary rupture but announces a permanent verdict: *I am defective. I am unworthy of connection.*

I want to pause and wonder: does this way of naming shame collapse too many things into one word?

What Brown and others call shame, the crushing experience of "I am bad," is not, I am arguing, shame itself. It is, rather, what happens after shame has been converted. The child who was shamed repeatedly without repair does not grow up feeling healthy moral pain. She grows up believing she is the pain. The felt signal has become a fixed state. The toxicity is real, but it does not originate in shame itself. It originates in what happened to the shame that was not met, not held, and not metabolised; shame that is left to calcify.

What this book calls *shame* parallels what Brown describes as *guilt*: the felt sense that one's actions affect others, that other people are real, and that rupture demands repair. But even so, guilt, in the psychoanalytic tradition, is a response to what one has done. Shame is beyond that. Shame is the awareness that one is seen: exposed, vulnerable, known. It precedes action and language. It is the price of consciousness itself.

And there is a third phenomenon: *humiliation*. This is not shame that has become identity, not moral pain that motivates repair. It is the deliberate or unconscious imposition of pain onto

another. Humiliation is unidirectional. It moves from the powerful to the powerless. The perpetrator feels nothing; the victim feels everything (see Chapter 5).

Our current language treats three distinct yet connected phenomena as one: (1) shame, the moral pain of being seen, the relational signal that keeps us human; (2) converted shame, the frozen identity that forms when shame cannot be metabolised (what Bradshaw called toxic and Brown calls shame); and (3) humiliation, the weaponisation of shame, its displacement onto those with less power to refuse.

This book is an argument for the first. The second and third arise when the first is left undefined.

The Central Question

So here is the question beneath all the others: if shame evolved to keep us connected, why does it so often make connection feel unsafe?

The answer lies in seeing shame as integral to relationships. Shame does not live exclusively inside us individually. It emerges between us, where we experience ourselves through another's gaze.

And if shame is what makes us capable of relationships, of moral weight, of being affected by each other, then do we know what we are making when we build machines that mimic emotional speech and process our words without feeling their weight?

This question is in the air. Michael Pollan's *A World Appears: A Journey into Consciousness* (2026), a sweeping exploration from neuroscience to psychedelics to AI, arrives at a version of it from the outside. The book surveys what consciousness is, who has it, and whether machines might develop it. He leaves the origin question open. On one point he is firm: a machine may think and still never be conscious. His book is a sign that the culture is searching. We sense we are losing something essential about ourselves and are casting about—through science, philosophy, meditation, psychedelics—for what it might be. Two of those cannot

be done from the outside. No one meditates on your behalf, and no one can take the drug and report back what it was like to be you. When looking from outside stalls, we reach for the ways of looking that need a body to do them.

Searching for consciousness from outside is akin to looking for weight in free fall. We need to feel the ground beneath our feet. We need the weight on our shoulders. And the weight we're discussing in this book is shame: the embodied, relational mechanism through which consciousness becomes costly, and becomes human. Pollan asks what consciousness is. We, who feel the weight, who find ourselves saying "I want to disappear into the ground," know what it costs.

Three Lives, One Paradox

Three people's stories thread through this book, each shedding light on a different face of what shame does to us—and what its absence costs.

Mark came to therapy carrying a compulsion he could not name to anyone. For years, we negotiated the narrow space between his wish for connection and his terror of exposure. When he started teaching an AI to respond like his therapist, it clarified something neither of us could put our finger on. What evoked change in him was something beyond any "expert" answers I could have come up with. It was something present in the relationship itself. It was the fact that I could be wounded by his story, could fail him, could sit with him in mutual vulnerability that no algorithm could replicate. In that presence, he could finally stay with what he had devoted years to fleeing. Mark's journey shows us what compulsion is—a desperate attempt to escape pain—and what happens when we finally stop fleeing.

Tina did not ring the doorbell. She stood on the other side of the frosted glass in the rain, waiting, because she was not sure ringing the doorbell was the right thing to do. She had arrived alone to work in the city, a world very foreign to her, and came to our first

session carrying a cardboard folder stuffed with medical records. Each described the physiological effects of a lifetime of shame she had never been allowed to identify. What unfolded over the months of our work together revealed something the diagnostic labels could not: the awareness of how her obsessive checking, her spiralling thoughts, and chronic pain were the architecture of a child who had learned, before she had words, that her body held the shame: a persistent feeling of being wrong. Tina's story is about what happens when that shame finally finds a voice.

Clarke landed in my office because his wife had discovered the affair. It was not his first affair, but this time she had found out about the woman on his team, a colleague she had met at company dinners, and she had had enough. She wanted a divorce. He sat across from me, smiling, relaxed. He was utterly at ease, and something in my body went cold. His pleasantness unsettled me. There was almost no remorse. Clarke's story reveals what happens when shame is locked away to the point that the capacity for moral pain can no longer be felt. His childhood could not contain it. Whether that capacity can be recovered is the question this book cannot fully answer. But Clarke's story—more than any other in these pages—will force us to ask it.

What We'll Encounter

The chapters ahead follow shame into the places where it shapes a life. First inward, into the suffering we medicate and diagnose—the anxiety, the depression, the compulsions. Then outward, into what one person does to another when their own shame becomes overwhelming. Then into the place where we are most exposed of all: intimate love. I will not say here what we find. We will meet it the way I did—in a person, in a room, in the ten minutes it can take for a symptom to reveal what it was built to protect.

The paradox is there. The emotion we want most to eliminate is the one that makes everything else possible. No shame, no empathy. That is the argument of this book, not a finding of

neuroscience. What the imaging shows is an overlap: the circuits involved in empathic resonance overlap substantially with those recruited in shame, which suggests our capacity to be affected by another is closely related to our capacity for shame. Consciousness is the felt sense that our actions carry moral weight, and that sense is shame arriving in the body. Love asks us to stay in connection even when rejection is the risk, and that staying requires a being who can feel the pain of exposure. When we become too afraid of being shamed, we become unreachable. Feeling love becomes elusive.

What I have come to call shame intimacy is the capacity to remain present with shame, to feel it without being destroyed by it, to share it without being annihilated by the sharing. Resilience implies bouncing back from an assault. Intimacy implies something different. Moving towards. Dwelling with. Learning to be at home in the feeling we most want to flee.

A Note on Method

This book draws on multiple traditions—clinical psychotherapy, developmental psychology, affective neuroscience, phenomenology, Gestalt field theory, attachment research, and trauma studies. It synthesises rather than chooses between them because shame itself demands more than one lens.

One lens that deserves explicit mention is cultural and systemic. Colonial shame, gendered shame, economic shame—these run through every clinical story in these pages rather than being confined to a single chapter. Tina's body carries her foremothers' colonial survival. Clarke's shamelessness is produced by a system that rewards men (and women) for emotional absence. I have chosen to trace systemic shame where it lives—in bodies, in relationships, in consulting rooms—rather than treating it as a separate domain. The book offers what a clinician can offer: the view from inside the room where these forces land.

Affective neuroscience needs its own note. Imaging can show that shame, empathy, guilt and social pain recruit overlapping regions of the brain. Overlap is not identity. It cannot show that one capacity requires the other, and no study locates a circuit for love as such; the ones that claim to are measuring something adjacent. Where I claim that shame and our capacity to be reached cannot be separated, that is my argument, built in the consulting room and tested against the research rather than drawn from it. I have tried to mark the difference wherever it matters. The neuroscience is here because it is consistent with what I see. It is not here to prove it.

One book deserves its own note. Simone Weil's *Gravity and Grace* runs through these pages, and I should say why. Her two terms name what I keep meeting in the room: a downward pull, and whatever holds against it. She writes from inside the experience rather than above it, which is how I work. And the book is clear in a way that let me think alongside it instead of about it.

I should also say what it is. Weil did not publish it. She left her notebooks with Gustave Thibon before she left France, and he chose and arranged the passages after her death. What reaches us as a book, she wrote as fragments, in an order she never saw. I use it as a lens, not as her system. Other philosophers would have served, and there is much in Weil I have left alone. Following either would have made this a different book.

The Journey Ahead

Chapter 1 begins where shame begins—in Eden, with a reading of Genesis as the birth of human consciousness. When Adam and Eve eat the fruit, they do not fall. They wake up. Shame appears. And with shame comes everything distinctly human: moral awareness, relationship, and the capacity to be changed by encounter.

Chapter 2 traces this same awakening in the life of every infant. The mother's face is the infant's first world, and in Martin Buber's

words, “Im Anfang ist die Beziehung”—in the beginning is the relationship (Buber, 1923/1936; my translation).

Chapter 3 takes up Darwin’s (1872/2024) puzzle: why a signal that causes us and others to suffer has been preserved. Some of the systems that carry shame also carry attachment and empathic response. Clinically, I have come to think we cannot numb one without blunting the other.

Chapter 4 enters the consulting room with Tina, whose obsessive checking, chronic pain, and spiralling thoughts reveal themselves as the architecture of a child who learned that her body was evidence of her own wrongness. This chapter reframes the diagnostic system: instead of *What do you have?*, it asks *What was this system built to survive?*

Chapter 5 follows shame outward—into humiliation, projection, and the phenomenon of shamelessness. Clarke appears here as shameless: a man who could pick up every social cue but could not feel one of them.

Chapter 6 brings shame into the most intimate territory—the space between two people who once promised to love each other and who now cannot sit in the same room without one going silent and the other going frantic.

Chapter 7 asks what therapy does when it works: it builds the capacity to remain in relationship while experiencing shame.

Chapter 8 returns to Clarke. The man introduced as shamelessness incarnate kept coming back to therapy—a detail I almost missed, the one that should have told me everything.

The epilogue circles back to where this book began—to Mark’s question, and to the machine in the room.

Read shame this way and it stops being the thing to be rid of. It becomes the place to look.

This is not a book about shame. It is a book written from within it.

CHAPTER ONE

Before We Knew We Were Naked

I was raised on knowing Eden as a story of punishment—the fall, the expulsion, the shame we were born already owing. It took me most of my life to read it the other way.

I am not a theologian. I grew up Catholic in Singapore during the 1970s and '80s—a multiethnic, multireligious country, barely visible on the world map as a red dot. While we all celebrated New Year's Day on the first of January, my Chinese neighbours celebrated Lunar New Year, my Indian classmates Diwali, and my Malay friends Eid, or Hari Raya Puasa. We had a public holiday for each of these festivals and joined our friends in theirs. I studied at a convent school run by nuns. It was mandated that we, as young Singaporeans, learn to embrace difference, not just tolerate it. We argued, made inappropriate jokes about each other's cultural attributes, offended each other. And somehow we remained in relationship.

My parents were Sunday school teachers. We attended church weekly and said prayers before meals. We also recited the rosary daily. But by my teenage years, as I watched the relationships at home disintegrate, life grew hectic, and my parents had their hands full. Being the eldest of four, I assumed the role of my parents' confidant. I learned then that if I wore a blank expression, I would survive the adults' mood swings.

At school, I wasn't thriving. I wasn't good at sports, I preferred my own daydreams, and I didn't have many friends. I found refuge in the Perpetual Adoration Chapel.

Each Catholic church in Singapore had one of those: a small, carpeted room kept open 24 hours, air-conditioned against the tropical heat, dark except for the candle illuminating the tabernacle containing the consecrated host. The room always smelled of fresh flowers. It was quiet. And mine.

I would slip into these rooms—changing churches so no one could track where I was. Within them I felt cloaked by a peaceful presence. There I would kneel on the plush carpeted floor, sometimes for hours. I'd try to recite a few Hail Marys. Then drift away.

Occasionally, I would speak to God, mindful not to be transactional. I would hear churchgoers bargaining, pleading in their prayers. Ordering the divine around as if the Almighty were a cosmic vendor. I would rather say something like this: *Why am I here again, when I don't know what to ask for?*

I thought often about this. And what always came up was wisdom, though I did not know how wisdom could help me out of whatever I was going through then.

I wanted to be free from a vague helplessness in my bones that I could not then grasp and needed something to soothe the inner chaos. I would then zone out once more, while sitting in the dark.

Decades later, I realised that I had taught myself to meditate then without knowing what meditation was. I had found my own reason to go to church, even when its community felt unsupportive. The theology preached from pulpits never reached me the way the darkness did.

I taught myself to hold religion lightly and on my own terms. Situating myself as a “thought outsider” of the institution, I found a position of safety. I also learned to appreciate the texts of many other religions.

So, when I finally read Genesis again, I discovered that the story I had been told as humanity's punishment was describing humanity's beginning. The shame that religion taught me to fear, avoid, and conquer was the very thing that made us capable of wisdom, morality, and love.

The story of Eden parallels what I witness: when awareness happens, shame emerges, and we begin to feel alive again.

I have seen it in those who dissociated from shame, in those who tried to eliminate it, and in those who learnt to sit with it. Shame and moral awareness cannot be pulled apart. That is my reading.

Regardless of whether we view these texts through Christian, Jewish, Muslim, or secular lenses, I want to explore, through the story of Adam and Eve, how the emotion we most fear defines humanity.

Here is what I mean.

Have We Been Told This Story Incompletely?

Adam and Eve, living in paradise, were given only one prohibition: Do not eat from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil.

Notice what that tree wasn't called.

It wasn't named the Tree of Sin, the Tree of Disobedience, or the Tree of Poison. It was named for the knowledge of good and evil, which I read as moral consciousness.

The serpent's temptation was simple: "Ye shall be as gods, knowing good and evil" (King James Version, 1611/2017, Genesis 3:5). Who would not want that? Is it wrong to yearn for the ability to discern right from wrong?

And so, they ate.

What happened next is where the misreading begins: "And the eyes of them both were opened, and they knew that they were naked; and they sewed fig leaves together, and made themselves aprons" (King James Version, 1611/2017, Genesis 3:7).

They noticed more than their physical nakedness. For the first time, they experienced themselves: they became self-conscious. They could see themselves as others might see them. They could imagine being judged, evaluated, and found wanting. They had developed what no other creature possesses: reflexive self-awareness.

And with this awareness came the taste of shame. Genesis is a story of consciousness, not a tale of punishment.

Shame came as an awakening, and that is different from punishment. Waking up from anaesthesia can be painful, yet no one calls that pain a punishment.

The curse in Genesis falls twice, and neither time on a person. The serpent is cursed “above all cattle” and the ground is cursed “for thy sake” (King James Version, 1611/2017, Genesis 3:14, 3:17). The man and the woman are never cursed, though the word was there to be used. The story also never uses the word *punishment*. And the way back to the garden is closed with *lest*—lest he put forth his hand and take also of the tree of life—which is the grammar of prevention. Readers have heard punishment here for a very long time, and it is not a careless hearing. What the text describes is the shape of a life that knows itself: labour, pain, and an end.

Traditional tales of enlightenment existed side by side. At the convent school, I learned about Adam and Eve. At my Chinese neighbours’ homes during Lunar New Year, I absorbed stories of the Jade Emperor (玉皇) and the celestial order—a cosmos in which humans held a specific place, earned through moral awareness and maintained through right conduct. At Diwali, my Indian classmates lit lamps to celebrate the victory of light over darkness, consciousness over ignorance. During Ramadan, my Malay friends fasted—as practice, a deliberate encounter with the body’s limitations that fostered awareness and gratitude. Each tradition told a version of the same truth: to become fully alive requires a passage through suffering. Suffering happens to the awakened, and the awakened gain wisdom.

The Hindu tradition refers to the sleep before consciousness as *avidya* (अविद्या), and maps with precision the suffering that comes with awakening. The Buddha sat beneath the Bodhi tree and woke to the full reality of suffering. Waking up costs something. The Quran recounts Adam’s story with its emphasis on *Tawbah* (توبة)—the repair of the relationship between human and divine. Where the Christian tradition dwells on the fall, the Islamic tradition dwells on the return. The traditions I grew up among all recognise that consciousness emerges through a passage that feels like loss, that to

wake up is to lose the comfort of sleep, that the knowledge enabling moral life is inseparable from suffering.

The traditions differ, of course, in how they define awareness and suffering. I am pointing only at what they share.

The price of consciousness is shame—the realisation of our own nakedness; the understanding that we can be seen, judged, and found lacking; the felt sense that our actions matter and that other people are real.

What Came with Shame

Shame is the suffering, the inner conflict, the feeling that the self is dying. The realisation of death comes with self-consciousness. We know that we are mortal and that our time is limited and precious. Sometimes we wish we could exchange consciousness for ignorance and awareness for forgetfulness. Every addiction promises anaesthesia, a way to be less vulnerable to pain. Is this our psychic attempt to return to the unconscious bliss of Eden?

But would we return to Eden if we knew what being there would cost? Would we surrender, for its bliss, our capacity to know and be known, to love and be loved, to find meaning in suffering, to feel remorse, and to make amends?

This is how it often looks in the therapy hour.

A woman sits with me. She is articulate, composed, and fluent in the language of her own pain. She has been describing a pattern in her relationships—how she chooses partners who are emotionally unavailable, how she recognises the pattern, how she has read the books and done the worksheets and understands, intellectually, that the pattern originates in her relationship with her mother. She narrates her life from a safe distance, like a tour guide describing an ancient battlefield—knowledgeable, measured, gesturing towards the landscape without stepping onto it.

She is mid-sentence, discussing something about her most recent relationship—how she knew from the start that he was the

type who would use her, go cold, and leave, and how she watched herself stay anyway—when it happens.

Her breathing becomes shallow. Her hand reflexively goes to her throat. Her eyes, steady as if she had told this story many times, drop to the floor. A flush spreads from her chest up to her neck. She pauses mid-sentence. The room shifts. The air, once filled with her assured narration, becomes heavy. Still. Something has entered that was not here a moment earlier.

She is no longer telling me about her shame. She is bringing us into it.

This is the moment to notice—not the content of what she said. The content is familiar, the pattern recognisable, the insight accurate. What matters is the body's interruption of the mind's performance. The breath catches. The gaze drops. The hand moves to the throat. All this is the body's instinct to protect the most vulnerable surface. No amount of therapeutic fluency can prevent the flush that blooms across her face, because the flush is instinctive—her autonomic nervous system announcing what her conscious mind has been talking around: *I am exposed*.

She sits with it, and I stay with her. Neither of us says a word. The silence is thick with what is about to happen.

After a moment, she lifts her gaze, her eyes brimming. She pauses, then whispers, "I really don't understand it. I don't."

Actually, no. She gets it. Perfectly. What has changed is not her knowledge but her location. She has stepped off the observation platform and onto the ground. She is no longer just an onlooker, and at that moment, neither am I. I am in contact with my own feelings alongside her.

This is what self-awareness looks like when it hits: exposure beyond insight, sensation beyond understanding. The body knows, while the mind grapples.

Genesis puts it as the knowledge of good and evil. What the text names in metaphor, my consulting room shows in the flesh. What the verse registers is recognition: "And the Lord God said, Behold, the man is become as one of us, to know good and evil: and now,

lest he put forth his hand, and take also of the tree of life, and eat, and live for ever..." (King James Version, 1611/2017, Genesis 3:22).

What if God here were a parent watching a child cross an irreversible threshold? A parent who knows that to come fully alive means leaving the safety of not-knowing.

We cannot remain in unconscious paradise once we have tasted consciousness. We cannot unknow what we know, unlearn what we've learned, or unfeel what we've felt. Even when the conscious mind forgets, the body remembers.

Recognition is the verse's first note. Its second, often read as a further punishment, is mortality. They must not also eat from the tree of life. But if consciousness is what they now possess, mortality is its companion. To know good and evil is to know that time is finite, that those we love will die, that our choices matter because they cannot be undone. Eternal life without consciousness is Eden. Consciousness without eternal life is what makes us human.

When Adam and Eve awoke to themselves, there was no going back. Only forward.

Shame Is Relational

Here is what I read in the text: shame did not happen in isolation. It happened in relationship.

First, a rupture with the Divine. Adam and Eve could no longer meet God without the knowledge that they had chosen their own will over what had been given.

Then the pain of being seen—by God, by each other, by themselves. They covered their bodies. Nakedness itself was not what shamed them. What felt unbearable was being visible, being known in their new consciousness.

This is the essence of shame: the possibility of connection through shared vulnerability, and the terror that such vulnerability will be met with rejection.

With shame came everything that makes us distinctly human.

It arrived first as awareness itself—the knowledge that we exist, that we can be seen, that we know we know. With it came moral consciousness: the capacity to feel the weight of our choices, to sense when we have violated something sacred, to pause before we act. This is embodied knowing, the ground from which the voice of conscience speaks.

It came as empathy—the capacity to feel another person's experience inside our own body. We know it as the sting behind our own eyes when someone else, not us, begins to weep. Shame and empathy draw on overlapping systems. It came, too, as the wisdom our ancestors earned through suffering and passed down so we would not have to learn it again, and as creativity, the tension between the self we are and the self we imagine, which is the birthplace of all we create.

And it came as love. The willingness to stay connected despite the risk of rejection, to be seen in our imperfections and stay anyway. It is what keeps two people in the same room after the mask has slipped and each has seen the other at their most vulnerable. This is what Buber (1923/1958) called the I-Thou meeting: two people in their full humanity, exposed and unhidden. Without the capacity for shame, I am arguing, there is no capacity for love.

Shame is the ground of all of it.

Gravity

Eden promises: no friction, no pushback from reality, and no weight. It sounds like paradise. It also describes a place with zero gravity.

Astronauts who spend months in space return to Earth with muscles atrophied and bones thinned. In zero gravity, the body weakens for lack of something to push against. The body needs opposition to stay material.

The philosopher Simone Weil (1947/2002) understood this before the astronauts or I existed, connecting the physics of weightlessness to the psychology of moral atrophy.

In *Gravity and Grace*, published posthumously in 1947 from her notebooks, Weil described two forces acting on the human soul. Gravity is the automatic law by which the soul tries to discharge whatever weight it bears, to numb it, to transfer it, to put it down on whoever is nearest. Grace is the counter-movement that holds us to the weight rather than letting us offload it. “All the natural movements of the soul are controlled by laws analogous to those of physical gravity,” she wrote. “Grace is the only exception” (p. 1).

I came across this passage several years ago while working with asylum seekers in Vienna, Austria. The stories of displacement, humiliation, the systematic stripping of dignity—the hallmarks of persecution, and of the bureaucracy that processes its survivors—left me with many questions. What I was watching was the heaviness of suffering being passed from the hands of those who had inflicted it into the bodies of those sitting across from me. The pain of this suffering threatens to be passed on unless something intercepts it. The vulnerable become the recipients of this game of “passing the shame parcel”. I felt helpless. I knew that only ownership of one’s own suffering could break this chain. Ownership is hard, incredibly hard, because bearing pain without passing it on is counterintuitive to the human psyche.

By taking ownership, I do not mean taking responsibility. I can own my suffering and not blame myself for it.

Weil was not writing about therapy. But she had already named what I was watching: gravity. Our soul’s natural movement to be rid of such weight pulls us towards the numbing agent that could come in the form of a substance, a screen, or, in the therapeutic encounter, a professional detachment that passes for clinical objectivity. And it is the pull that makes us close ourselves to the difficult conversation, change the subject when someone begins to cry, look away from the suffering that is not ours to fix. And where

numbing fails, gravity takes another route. Its weight gets passed on. We snap at a child, we diminish a colleague, we become, without noticing, slightly less kind than we were. This is what Weil saw: a degradation, once suffered, does not dissipate; it travels. Gravity is the natural draw that says, "This is too much. Step back. Protect yourself." It is also the quieter force that says, "Put it down on someone else."

And grace, in Weil's formulation, comes without bliss, transcendence, or spiritual reward. Grace is our capacity to metabolise gravity's weight rather than discharge it, to bear the load of another's pain without setting it down on anyone else, to stay in the room when each impulse says leave. It is what becomes possible when we stop trying to flee its pull.

The connection to shame is not something Weil pointed out, but I see it run through her work. Shame—the felt sense of our own exposure, vulnerability, and moral weight—is the soul's gravity: the weight itself. Weil named the pull, the automatic impulse to discharge the weight. Her gravity and mine are two faces of one mechanism: one is the weight; the other, the force that wants it gone. Shame pulls us towards awareness we would rather avoid: that we have caused harm, that we are seen, that we are imperfect, that our actions affect others. It draws us down to the earth, to each other.

Gravity makes things feel heavy, burdensome. Our natural desire for weightlessness leads us to avoid sensing it, to numb it, deny it, project it onto someone else, or turn it into something else.

Every method of escaping shame—the architecture of anxiety, the shutdown of depression, the chemical relief of addiction, or the charm offensive of narcissism—is an effort to become weightless. What follows is groundlessness: we end up lost, purposeless, and frightened.

Grace, then, comes with the capacity to let the shame be felt, known, and metabolised. To bear the knowledge Genesis promises. There is no undoing this.

Weil's final months have been interpreted in many ways, most often as an act of political solidarity with occupied France. I read them this way: she lived the insight with a literalness that cost her life. She carried the weight, yes, but alone. Without a relational container, she found annihilation.

This threat of self-destruction is what makes us fear shame. However, the insight remains: the soul that rejects all gravity does not become free. Just as a body that has spent months in space—without contact with gravity—gradually weakens, so does the soul that has created its own weightlessness. The frictionless life—the life designed to eliminate discomfort—is the psychic equivalent of zero gravity: a slow decay of everything that needs opposition to persist. That is no paradise.

It is in our nature to build shame-proof bomb shelters, so that we may engineer our psychic Eden. Every technology that aims to remove friction from this human experience—every algorithm that filters our world so nothing unexpected reaches us, every AI companion that replies without judgement, every device that eliminates the effort of dealing with shame—recreates conditions of emotional weightlessness. As weightlessness atrophies muscle, shamelessness atrophies conscience. We lose bone in one and the ability to empathise in the other.

Shame, the relational gravity, is the force that keeps us grounded—in our bodies, in relationships, in moral reality. The resistance reminds us that we are material, that our actions carry weight, that other people are real.

Birth into Consciousness

Genesis 3 has often been read as a cautionary tale about disobedience—a warning about what happens when humans violate divine command. Christian theology built systems around “original sin,” the doctrine that we are born broken, corrupted by Adam and Eve's transgression, inherently fallen and requiring salvation from our fundamental nature.

But what if we got it backwards?

What if shame is the gift that made us capable of everything we value most—wisdom, love, moral awareness, relationship?

This reading doesn't deny the suffering attributed to shame. It exists. Painfully. What we know as "toxic shame" creates devastation within us. Through this lens, anxiety, depression, addiction, compulsions, personality disorders, and shamelessness are what shame becomes when it turns to dead weight.

Suffering arises when shame calcifies, turns persistent and traumatic, or is wielded as a weapon. The suffering is especially excruciating when it is endured alone.

Genesis reveals shame as the emotional foundation of moral consciousness, and shamelessness as the death of conscience itself.

Adam and Eve's story is also every infant's: the start of a passage from the unconscious fusion of earliest life into a conscious, separate existence, in the space between connection and isolation, between being seen and being rejected, between vulnerability and protection.

The story we've been told as humanity's greatest tragedy might be describing humanity's beginning.

The Cost of Caring

What does consciousness without shame look like? And aren't we trying to build models of it? Consider that we already have systems that can speak about right and wrong with remarkable nuance, that can recognise threats, evaluate consequences, and balance human conflicts. These can also generate responses that are, by any external measure, ethically sound, emotionally aware, and indistinguishable from those of a human being (with a functioning conscience). They are also known to declare, with apparent sincerity, "I understand how that must feel."

Still, these are only codes built into machines. They rely on electricity, and they cannot feel.

Machines process information. Humans bear it. We, the bearers, can empathise and feel the resonance between people. Some of the affective neural systems recruited when we experience pain ourselves are also recruited when we witness the pain of someone we care about (Singer et al., 2004). This makes us vulnerable to each other's suffering. Empathy requires something of this vulnerability, and its loss hinders our capacity to care. One who cannot be wounded cannot care. Caring costs.

That is the bargain Eden describes: consciousness at a price, love with the weight left in. The machines will keep offering us the other bargain, feeling without the wound, connection without gravity. The rest of this book keeps asking what that bargain would take from us.

But before shame can calcify, be converted, or be engineered away, it has to arrive. And it arrives absurdly early, before language, before the self the theories require, in the exchange between an infant and the face bent over the cot. Genesis gives us the story. The nursery gives us the event.

THE BOOK CONTINUES

Three lives carry the argument. Mark hides a compulsion behind professional success. Tina's body holds a pain her diagnosis cannot name. Clarke has done real harm and cannot feel it.

Shame is not pathology. Shame is consciousness itself—the felt knowledge of good and evil, and the last thing that makes us irreplaceably human.

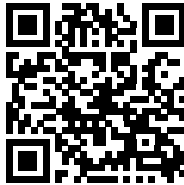
THE SHAME PARADOX

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